

New Zealand Fjords

A group of fjords in the southwestern corner of New Zealand, featuring abundant marine life and spectacular cliffs and waterfalls



New Zealand's fjords formed some 15,000 years ago when glaciers retreated at the end of the last ice age and the sea flooded in to fill the deep, U-shaped coastal valleys carved out by the glaciers.

Dangerous discovery

Of some 14 major fjords, two of the best known are Doubtful Sound—one of the largest at 20 miles (30km) in length—and Milford Sound. The former was named in 1770 by Captain James Cook, who refrained from sailing into it because he doubted that he would ever be able to sail out again. The smaller but more famous Milford Sound, which runs 9 miles

(15km) inland, is notable for the spectacular waterfalls that rain down into it, and an enormous mountain—the 5,551-ft- (1,692-m-) high Mitre Peak—that soars above it. Both of these fjords, and others nearby, are home to bottlenose and dusky dolphins, New Zealand fur seals, little penguins, and the rare Fiordland crested penguin. Prevailing westerly winds blowing moist air in from the Tasman Sea produce exceedingly high rainfall across the region, and this supports lush temperate rain forests close by.



◁ CURIOUS MINERAL

Small deposits of arsenopyrite are found in the region. If heated, the mineral gives off toxic fumes and becomes magnetic. If struck with a hammer, it emits a garliclike odor.

▽ MISTY CASCADE

The 495-ft (-151-m-) high Stirling Falls is one of two permanent waterfalls in Milford Sound. Its Maori name is Wai Manu, meaning "cloud on the water."

